

The Blindness of Aseity:

No system can know its own groundlessness in the outward-reaching form

The claim. A system S possesses *aseity* if nothing external grounds it. Stated fully, this is the negative formula $U(S) \equiv \neg \exists x (\text{Ext}(x) \wedge \text{Grounds}(x, S))$, which quantifies over the exterior. There is also a positive form, $U^+(S) \equiv \neg \exists x \text{Grounds}(x, S)$, which makes the same groundlessness claim without the externality marker. The argument, machine-checked in Lean 4 without `sorry`, classical choice, or propositional extensionality, is that no epistemically closed system—not even one omniscient over everything within itself—can *know* $U(S)$ of itself, although it may perfectly well know $U^+(S)$.

The language and the reach predicate. Formulas are built from atoms $\text{Ext}(x)$ and $\text{Grounds}(x, S)$ by $\neg$, $\wedge$, and $\exists$. A formula is *outward-reaching*, written $\text{About}(\varphi)$, iff it contains a *realized* occurrence of Ext : reference, not bare sense, so the existential clause demands a witnessing object, $\text{About}(\exists x. \varphi(x)) \iff \exists x. \text{About}(\varphi(x))$.

Lemma 1. $\text{About}(U(S)) \iff \text{Obj} \neq \emptyset$, and $\neg \text{About}(U^+(S))$ unconditionally.

Sketch. Any witness x realizes the conjunct $\text{Ext}(x)$ inside $U(S)$; conversely a realized occurrence supplies a witness. U^+ contains no Ext atom at all, so no ontology can make it reach outward. $\square$

The axioms. Five principles govern knowledge $\mathbf{K}$, belief set $\mathfrak{B}$, closure Cl , accessibility Acc , and interiority Within :

$$\begin{array}{ll} (\text{G1}) \text{Acc}_S \varphi \rightarrow \text{Within}_S \varphi & (\text{G3}) \varphi \in \mathfrak{B}_S \rightarrow \text{Acc}_S \varphi \\ (\text{W2E}) \text{Within}_S \varphi \rightarrow \neg \text{About}(\varphi) & (\text{CIW}) (\forall \psi \in \mathfrak{B}_S. \text{Within}_S \psi) \rightarrow (\text{Cl}_S \varphi \rightarrow \text{Within}_S \varphi) \\ (\text{J}) \mathbf{K}_S \varphi \rightarrow \text{Cl}_S \varphi \end{array}$$

Each is individually plausible: what a system can access lies within it; its beliefs are accessible to it; what lies within does not itself reach outward; inferential closure cannot manufacture outward reference from inward premises; and knowledge implies membership in the closure of belief.

Theorem 1 (C1). *If the exterior is inhabited, then $\neg \mathbf{K}_S U(S)$ for every S —in particular for $S = g$, and even under within-omniscience ($\forall \varphi. \text{Within}_g \varphi \rightarrow \mathbf{K}_g \varphi$).*

Sketch. By G3 and G1, every believed formula lies within S ; by CIW, so does everything in the closure of belief. Suppose $\mathbf{K}_S U(S)$. By J, $U(S) \in \text{Cl}_S$, hence $\text{Within}_S U(S)$, hence by W2E $\neg \text{About}(U(S))$ —contradicting the Lemma, since $\text{Obj} \neq \emptyset$. A corollary by the same route: $U(S) \notin \mathfrak{B}_S$; the aseity cannot even be believed. $\square$

Why the result is not vacuous. Set every predicate to the uniform internalist model $M_S(\varphi) \equiv \neg \text{About}(\varphi)$. All five axioms hold by identity maps, the system is within-omniscient, and it *does* know $U^+(S)$ —so a rich, consistent epistemic life is compatible with the axioms; only the outward-reaching form is blind-spotted. The independence of the axioms is likewise verified: for each of the five there is a countermodel over the unit type satisfying the other four in which $\mathbf{K}U$ holds, so no four suffice. The three interior layers $\mathfrak{B} \subseteq \text{Acc} \subseteq \text{Within}$ are shown strictly ordered by explicit separating formulas.

Creation. Index the ontology by stages, $\text{Obj} : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \text{Type}$, holding the epistemic architecture fixed. Before creation ($\text{Obj}_t = \emptyset$) the model knows $U(g)$, since nothing realizes the Ext clause; at any stage with an inhabited exterior, Theorem C1 applies. Knowledge of one’s own aseity, in its full outward-reaching sense, does not survive the first act of creation: to make an exterior is to lose the ability to know, from within, that nothing in it grounds you.